

Self-Service Returns & Refunds Portal

Business Requirements Document v0.9 (draft for review) | Owner: Marco Bianchi, Head of Commercial Operations | Circulated 14 March

1. Context

Nordwind Retail Group processes an average of 8,200 customer returns per month across its four distribution centres in Hamburg, Venlo, Milan and Poznan. Volume is strongly seasonal: January 2025 peaked at 19,000 returns in a single month, roughly 2.3 times the annual average.

Returns today are handled manually. A customer emails a shared mailbox, an agent replies with a return authorisation and a label, and the refund is raised by hand once the parcel is booked in. Average time to first response is 3.5 days and rises above nine days during the January peak. Each return generates on average 1.8 contact-centre interactions at a fully loaded cost of EUR 4.20 per interaction. Customer Service reports that approximately 40 percent of all inbound contacts are some variation of “where is my refund”.

The manual process also leaves no structured record of why a return was accepted or rejected, which has been raised twice by internal audit.

2. Objectives

- Reduce time to first response from 3.5 days to under 10 minutes for standard returns.
- Remove at least 60 percent of returns-related contact-centre interactions.
- Give customers a self-service view of return and refund status at any time.
- Produce a structured, retained record of every return decision.

3. Scope

Phase 1 covers business-to-consumer returns for goods sold and dispatched by Nordwind in Germany, Austria and the Netherlands. The portal must be available in German, Dutch and English.

The following are explicitly out of scope for phase 1:

- Exchanges. A customer who wants a different size returns the item and places a new order.
- Business-to-business and wholesale returns, which follow a separate contractual process.
- Any change to the checkout or order-placement flow.

4. Functional requirements

Ref	Requirement	Priority
BR-01	A customer must be able to raise a return request from the order history page without contacting Customer Service.	Must
BR-02	The system must accept a return request within 14 calendar days of delivery . Requests after that window must be rejected automatically with an explanation.	Must
BR-03	The customer must select a return reason from a fixed list: damaged in transit, wrong item received, does not fit, changed mind, delivered late.	Must
BR-04	A printable return label must be generated immediately when the request is submitted, so the customer can drop the parcel off the same day.	Must
BR-05	Returns are free of charge for orders with a value of EUR 50 or above . Below that threshold a flat handling fee of EUR 3.90 is deducted from the refund.	Must
BR-06	The refund must be issued within 5 business days of the goods being booked in at the distribution centre.	Must
BR-07	The customer must be able to see the status of a return at any time without logging a contact.	Must
BR-08	Returns flagged as suspicious must be routed to a manual review queue rather than refunded automatically. Approximately 2.5 percent of returns are currently associated with suspected serial returners.	Should
BR-09	Distribution-centre staff must be able to record the condition of returned goods on arrival.	Should
BR-10	The portal must be usable on a mobile phone; 71 percent of order-history traffic is mobile.	Should

5. Service levels

Measure	Target
Time to return authorisation	Under 10 minutes, 95th percentile
Refund issued after goods booked in	5 business days
Portal availability	99.5 percent during 06:00-24:00 CET
Concurrent users at January peak	400

6. Compliance

The portal processes customer personal data and is subject to GDPR. Personal data associated with a return must be retained for **24 months** and deleted thereafter. All processing must take place within the European Union.

7. Open items

- Whether returns of items sold by third-party marketplace sellers are in scope has not been decided. Commercial and Legal hold different views.
- Poland has not been confirmed for the launch wave.
- The commercial impact of extending the return window beyond the statutory minimum has not been modelled.

This document reflects the commercial view. Technical feasibility of the service levels in section 5 has not yet been confirmed with Enterprise Architecture.